



A meeting of the Special Committee on Gender Mainstreaming held today

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Islamabad, April 7, 2026:

A meeting of the Special Committee on Gender Mainstreaming was held today in the Constitution Room, Parliament House, Islamabad, under the chairpersonship of Hon. Dr. Nafisa Shah, MNA.

The Committee was comprehensively briefed on the poverty measurement methodologies currently in use, with particular emphasis on the integration of gender-disaggregated data to support inclusive and evidence-based policymaking. The briefing covered the evolution of poverty estimation by the Planning Commission, the Cost of Basic Needs (CBN) methodology as the principal framework for assessing poverty, and the methodological approach for the 2024–25 poverty estimates, including key indicators, data sources, and analytical tools. The Committee was also apprised of the institutional framework, recent poverty trends, national poverty rates, and detailed poverty headcount statistics at the national, regional, and provincial levels.

The Committee was updated on the results of the poverty headcount at both National and Provincial levels, noting an overall increase of 7 percent in the poverty line between 2018–19 and 2024–25. The Committee was informed that the poverty headcount figure increased from 3,757.85 in 2018–19 to 8,483.8 in 2024–25, reflecting a significant rise over the period.

The Chairperson Special Committee on Gender mainstreaming took serious notice of the significant increase in poverty lines at both national and provincial levels. Expressing deep concern over the figures presented, the Hon. Chairperson observed that the data was extremely painful and deeply disturbing, noting with grave concern that nearly every second household appears to be living below the poverty line. She termed the situation alarming and called upon the Ministry to provide a comprehensive explanation for the sharp rise in poverty across the country, along with practical, result-oriented proposals aimed at poverty reduction and eventual eradication.

The Committee further observed that rapid population growth has adversely affected service delivery mechanisms, thereby exacerbating the prevailing poverty situation on the ground. Members noted that the widening gap between available resources and the growing needs of the population continues to intensify socio-economic vulnerabilities. The Committee also expressed concern over the institutional response and overall attitude of departments tasked with addressing poverty-related challenges, emphasizing the need for greater coordination, efficiency, and responsiveness.

The Hon. Members expressed concern that ongoing international developments and global economic uncertainties could further exacerbate poverty levels. They urged the relevant departments to adopt a proactive, solution-oriented approach and implement timely interventions to mitigate the anticipated impact. Special attention was also drawn to the adverse effects of climate change on livelihoods, food security, and economic stability, which disproportionately affect vulnerable populations. The Committee emphasized the need for climate-resilient policies and timely planning to address poverty-related challenges arising from environmental and climatic factors.

The Committee further highlighted the rapid increase in population and stressed the importance of formulating effective population management and control measures, alongside sustainable and awareness-based interventions. Members also noted that policy efforts would be ineffective without clear and

standardized benchmarks for poverty evaluation, particularly in remote and underdeveloped areas. The Committee underscored the necessity of adopting a uniform, transparent, and region-sensitive poverty assessment framework to accurately identify affected populations and enable more targeted and effective policy responses.

The Committee was briefed by the Additional Secretary, Ministry of Poverty Alleviation and Social Safety, and the Director General of the Pakistan Poverty Alleviation Fund (PPAF) on the organization's performance, with particular focus on its outreach to women beneficiaries. The briefing highlighted PPAF's vision, mandate, institutional structure, and its poverty graduation approach aimed at enabling vulnerable households, especially women and marginalized communities, to transition from dependency towards sustainable livelihoods and economic self-reliance. It was further informed that PPAF's initiatives are aligned with the national development agenda, particularly in the areas of women's empowerment, financial inclusion, social protection, and community-based development through livelihood support, skills development, microfinance, and social safety interventions.

During the discussion, the Hon. Chair and Members raised critical questions regarding the effectiveness, transparency, and sustainability of PPAF's interventions, particularly their impact on poverty reduction and women's empowerment. The Committee sought clarity on the number of beneficiaries who had graduated out of poverty, the assessment criteria, and gender-disaggregated, district-wise data to evaluate outreach in

rural and underserved areas. Concerns were also expressed regarding fund allocation, administrative costs, audit mechanisms, provincial distribution, inclusion of climate-affected communities, and coordination with other poverty alleviation institutions to ensure evidence-based, equitable, and sustainable support for vulnerable households.

After detailed discussion, the Committee deferred further deliberation on the agenda item and decided that a comprehensive briefing by the Pakistan Poverty Alleviation Fund (PPAF), addressing the questions and concerns raised by the Hon. Members, shall be arranged in a subsequent meeting. The Committee also decided to undertake a visit to the relevant offices/field projects of PPAF to obtain first-hand insight into the implementation and impact of its programmes, particularly those concerning women beneficiaries and poverty alleviation initiatives.

The Committee deferred the briefing on Pakistan Bait-ul-Mal to the next meeting for detailed consideration.

The Committee constituted a Sub-Committee under the convenorship of Ms. Shaista Pervaiz, MNA. The Sub-Committee shall comprise Ms. Shahida Rehmani, MNA; Ms. Shahida Begum, MNA; Ms. Munaza Hassan, MNA; and Senator Khalida Ateeq. The Sub-Committee was tasked to review the issues raised during the briefing, undertake the proposed visit, and submit its recommendations to the main Committee for further deliberation.

The Chair approved the minutes of the previous meetings of the Committee.

The meeting was attended by Senator Saadia Abbasi, Senator Khalida Ateeq, Ms. Shaista Pervaiz, Ms. Shahida Rehmani and Ms. Munaza Hassan, MNAs. Barrister Aqeel Malik, Minister of State for Law and Justice, along with Additional Secretary, Ministry of PASS, Joint Chief Economist, Ministry of Planning and Development and Special Initiatives, senior officers and officials from the Ministry of Human Rights, Poverty Alleviation and Social Safety, and Ministry of Planning and Development also attended the meeting.